Run the Race Set Before You

Because believers are complete in Christ and the Law’s decrees were nailed to the cross, no one may judge them by Mosaic rules or disqualify them from their prize through false humility, mysticism or asceticism — none of which has any value against the flesh.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8 **Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	**02 1:9–14** **Paul's Prayer for the Colossians**	**03 1:15–23** **The Savior of the Gospel**	**04 1:24–29** **Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**
05 2:1–7 **The Believer's Education**	**06 2:8–15** **Beware of Philosophy**	**07 2:16–23** **Run the Race Set Before You**	**08 3:1–11** **Looking Up, Putting Off**
09 3:12–17 **Service Manual for the Lord's Army**	**10 3:18–4:1** **The Relationships of the New Man**	**11 4:2–6** **Perfecting the Prayer Life**	**12 4:7–18** **Portrait of a Ministry Team**

Five areas — no one is to judge you

Colossians 2:16 · Outline I.A — The areas of the judging

Food	Clean and unclean (Lev 11:3) — but Jesus “declared all foods clean” (Mark 7:19; cf. 1 Tim 4:3–5)	**βρῶσις** the act of eating, food
Drink	Little in the Law itself; the false teachers likely added ascetic rules (cf. Rom 14:17)	**—** vessels · Nazirite vows
Festival	Unleavened Bread, Weeks and Booths — three times a year (Deut 16:16)	**—** the annual feasts
New moon	Monthly offerings (Num 29:6); cf. Gal 4:10, “days and months and seasons”	**νεομηνία** the monthly observance
Sabbath	The only one of the Ten Commandments not repeated as a command for the Church	**σάββατον** the weekly day of rest

Believers may abstain for health or conscience (Rom 14) — but no one may make such rules a measure of spirituality.

The shadow and the substance

Colossians 2:17 · Outline I.B — The error of the judging

The shadow
σκιά skia · G4639

- A mere outline — shape without substance
- The Sabbath foreshadowed rest in Christ (Heb 4:9–10)
- Passover pictured Christ, “our Passover” (1 Cor 5:7)
- Visible, measurable, manageable — and empty

vs

The substance
σῶμα sōma · “body”

- “The substance belongs to Christ”
- He is the body that casts the shadow (Heb 10:1)
- The realities of the New Covenant
- Why grasp the shadow when you have the Person?

Strangely, people grasp what seems visible and manageable — and miss the Christ the shadows point to.

Defrauded of the prize

Colossians 2:18–19 · Outline II — Don’t let anyone disqualify you

1 False humility

ταπεινοφροσύνη
Delighting in self-abasement — the minute you know you are humble, you are not

2 Worship of angels

θρησκεία
“Humbly” approaching angels — yet every believer may come directly (Heb 4:16; Rev 19:10)

3 Visions

ἐμβατεύω
Taking a stand on visions — as an initiate enters a mystery shrine

4 Pride

φυσιόω
Puffed up like a bellows “by his fleshly mind”

5 Not holding the Head

The root problem: life, nourishment, unity and growth flow only from Christ (v.19)

★ The prize at stake

καταβραβεύω
Reward for faithful running — not eternal life, which is a free gift

Dead to the world’s religion

Colossians 2:20–22 · Outline III.A — The question

The assumption	The inquiry	The prohibitions	The explanation
“If (since) you have died with Christ to the elementary principles of the world”	**δογματίζω** “Why … do you submit yourself to decrees?” — let yourself be “dogmatized”	“Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!” — and the list keeps growing	Perishable things, human commandments — food goes into the stomach, not the heart (Mark 7:19)
v.20a · first class condition	v.20b	v.21	v.22

Dead to sin (Rom 6:2), to self (2 Cor 5:14–15), to the Law (Rom 7:4, 6), to the world (Gal 6:14) — and here, to the world’s religion.

The appearance of wisdom — and the verdict

Colossians 2:23 · Outline III.B — The answer

They appear to be wise
ἐθελοθρησκία · “self-made religion”

- Self-chosen worship
- Self-abasement
- Severe treatment of the body
- People like to be challenged to deny themselves

vs

They have no value
πλησμονή · “indulgence”

- Of no value against fleshly indulgence
- Rules may change behavior on the surface for a while
- They cannot change the heart
- The flesh grows proud of its own rule-keeping

Four counterfeit “higher” paths: higher knowledge, higher practice, higher contemplation, higher retreat. Christ is enough.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 2:16–23 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What is the “prize” in verse 18, and how could a believer lose it?

2. If rules cannot stop the flesh, what can?

Apply

Enjoy Your Freedom Without Judging Others
Identify one extra-biblical rule you have used to measure spirituality and lay it down this week.

Hold Fast to the Head
Set aside fifteen unhurried minutes each day for Scripture and prayer, beginning with Colossians 1:15–20.

In one line: Don’t trade the substance for the shadow: run your race holding fast to the Head, not to a list of rules.